

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

GLOBAL SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

PIA3142 | WEEK 2: SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORY

SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

SOME DEFINITIONS

“Social movements can be viewed as collective enterprises to establish a new order of life. They have their inception in the condition of unrest, and derive their motive power on one hand from dissatisfaction with the current form of life, and on the other hand, from wishes and hopes for a new scheme or system of living” (Blumer 1939).

“A social movement is a collectivity acting with some continuity to promote or resist a change in the society or organization of which it is a part. As a collectivity a movement is a group with indefinite and shifting membership and with leadership whose position is determined more by informal response of the members than by formal procedures for legitimating authority” (Turner & Killian 1972).

Social movements are "those organized efforts, on the part of excluded groups, to promote or resist changes in the structure of society that involve recourse to noninstitutional forms of political participation” (McAdam 1982).

Note the distinction between “social movement” and “social movement organization."

SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

SOME DEFINITIONS

Social movements and SMOs vary on many different dimensions. Among them:

* The causes they promote/espouse, or their goals (ranging from radical re-organization of society to narrowly defined issues);
* Their spatial/political organization (local, national, transnational);
* The nature of the actors/organizations/institutions on which social movements make their demands (inter-governmental orgs, non-governmental orgs, national governments, corporations);
* The methods/tactics they use.

KEY QUESTIONS

WE COVER IN THIS COURSE

* What does it take for people rebel against, or participate in social movements pressing demands on, authority?
* What are the main forces that drive them to get involved? Under what conditions are they likely to do so? How do they become willing to die for others?
* How does mass participation translate into social (sometimes revolutionary) change? What makes a given movement more or less successful?
* How does globalization affect domestic patterns of contentious politics?

Note that, as it is often the case in the social sciences, there is a lot of disagreement about what the right answers are.

RELATIVE DEPRIVATION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Theory borrowed from social psychology, put forth in Ted Robert Gurr's book *Why Men Rebel* (1970).

KEY ASSUMPTION:
Most dangerous source of political violence is the frustration-aggression mechanism; prolonged feeling of frustration will lead to anger/violence.

SOURCE OF FRUSTRATION:
Not necessarily based on how bad things are in "absolute" terms, because people can get used to living in terrible circumstances.

RELATIVE DEPRIVATION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

What matters is “RELATIVE DEPRIVATION,” which is the difference between what a person has and what the person in question believes he/she deserves.

MAIN HYPOTHESIS:

“The potential for collective violence varies strongly with the intensity and scope of relative deprivation among members of a collectivity.”

“Relative deprivation” is what causes frustration (and, by extension, aggression); “absolute deprivation” only causes desperation.

Implication: The groups most likely to protest and to engage in violence are the most (relatively) deprived.

RELATIVE DEPRIVATION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

PROBLEM:

It's unclear exactly how "relative deprivation" works as a causal force.

Is it a "sufficient cause"?
Clearly not, because many "relatively deprived" people/groups do not protest.

Is it a "necessary cause," or a "contributing cause"?
Maybe, but saying that people who protest are seeking redress for some grievance (or are attempting to get something they believe they're entitled to) isn't much of an answer, as it's pretty obvious.

RELATIVE DEPRIVATION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Does the intensity of participation increase with the depth of one's *perceived* "relative deprivation"?

That's possible, insofar as "relative deprivation" is more a matter of feeling than it is a function of objective, material conditions.

However, that raises a couple other questions:

[i] How do members of a group come to feel "relatively deprived" in a similar way? Given that their material condition is of secondary importance, it's unlikely this takes place spontaneously. Deeply felt, shared grievances are more commonly the result than the cause of political mobilization.

RELATIVE DEPRIVATION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

[ii] Often, people with intense feelings of "relative deprivation" do nothing about it. Even in cases where there is a movement to be joined to address a set of grievances, feeling deprived is usually not a strong enough motivator to participate in its activities.

Why?

Because even aggrieved people think; and "thinking" (at least, thinking rationally) often makes them inclined to sit back, "free ride," and let others do the work.

This is what is called "the collective action problem."

COLLECTIVE ACTION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Mancur Olson's book *The Logic of Collective Action* (1965) demonstrated that rational individuals with common grievances/interests do NOT have an incentive to form or join organizations that further those interests.

Why? Collective action is about the provision of "public goods" (PGs); PGs are "non-excludable" in the sense that one cannot discriminate between "participant" and "free-rider" when such goods are distributed. Either everyone enjoys them, or no one does.

In turn, the "non-excludable" nature of PGs places one's personal or private interest is in contrast with common, group interests. Why?

COLLECTIVE ACTION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

[i] Because people do care about "public goods", but they also have an interest in maximizing their own income, or saving time, energy, and other "private" resources. And participating in the provision of a "public good" involves "private" costs;

[ii] Because, if the group is large enough, a single person has no effect on whether the group will succeed or fail.

Given that each individual in the group will either enjoy or will not enjoy the public good regardless of his/her individual participation (depending on whether the group as a whole succeeds or fails), individuals have an incentive to "free ride" and wait for others to act.

And, if everyone thinks this way, nobody will ever do anything.

COLLECTIVE ACTION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Suppose Jane lives in an autocratic society and is deciding whether to join a pro-democracy demonstration. Assume for simplicity that if everyone who supports the cause attends the demonstration, democracy will be established.

		EVERYONE ELSE: PROTEST	EVERYONE ELSE: STAY HOME
JANE: PROTEST		BENEFIT: Democracy COST: Time lost	BENEFIT: None COST: Time lost
JANE: STAY HOME		BENEFIT: Democracy COST: None	BENEFIT: None COST: None

What should Jane do? If she is "instrumentally rational"—meaning, if she takes the course of action that guarantees the highest payoff (calculated as benefits minus costs)—she will always stay home. If everyone thinks this way, the demonstration will fail.

RATIONAL CHOICE

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Proponents of so-called "Rational Choice Theory" typically argue that people in Jane's situation could be made rationally to participate if there is an organization that administers either:

(i) Selective incentives: Unlike PGs, these are "excludable" benefits; that is, benefits that are only given to those who actively participate. This could be money, or something else (including, potentially, "social benefits");

(ii) Selective disincentives: These are sanctions/penalties assessed on those who do not participate (thereby making it "costly" to stay home). The most obvious is physical coercion/violence; but, individuals may also be targeted with "social sanctions."

RATIONAL CHOICE

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

What's the problem?

This reasoning, which is based on a definition of rationality that centers on self-interest, explains why people DO NOT act; it is much less useful in explaining actual participation (why some people DO act).

That's fine, given that most people in most situations do not protest.

But, it isn't particularly interesting—people who stay home usually don't make history.

The point is that it's not especially useful to think of protest as the result of deprivation or self-interest alone.

RATIONAL CHOICE

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Deprivation is not enough for most people *to* participate (otherwise, there would be protest everywhere all the time).

At the same time, self-interest is often not powerful enough to keep people *from* participating (otherwise, few would ever protest).

So, a great deal more interesting is the manner in which social movements:

* Actively foster shared feelings of grievance among their followers; and
* Translate such grievances into action, often by inducing their followers to overlook self-interest.

NON-VOLUNTARISM

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

One possible "solution" to the collective action problem, set forth most famously in Theda Skocpol's 1979 book *States and Social Revolutions*, is that the focus on the grievances and rationality of individuals is simply misguided.

Skocpol offered a "non-voluntaristic" approach, claiming that no revolution has ever been "made" by revolutionaries.

A good explanation, therefore, requires rising above the viewpoints, the grievances, and the interests of the actual participants.

The key claim is that revolutions have "structural" causes, to be found especially in the international and socio-economic context in which a particular society finds itself at a particular time.

NON-VOLUNTARISM

How, then, are social revolutions to be explained? Where are we to turn for fruitful modes of analyzing their causes and outcomes? In my view, existing social-scientific theories of revolution are not adequate.[7] In consequence, the chief purpose of this chapter is to introduce and defend principles and methods of analysis that represent alternatives to those shared by all (or most) existing approaches. I shall argue that, in contrast to the modes of explanation used by the currently prevalent theories, social revolutions should be analyzed from a structural perspective, with special attention devoted to international contexts and to developments at home and abroad that affect the breakdown of the state organizations of old regimes and the buildup of new, revolutionary state organizations. Fur-

—Theda Skocpol. 1979. *States and Social Revolutions*. Cambridge University Press (p.5).

NON-VOLUNTARISM

More important, the purposive image is very misleading about both the causes and the processes of social revolutions that have actually occurred historically. As for causes, no matter what form social revolutions conceivably might take in the future (say in an industrialized, liberal-democratic nation), the fact is that historically no successful social revolution has ever been "made" by a mass-mobilizing, avowedly revolutionary movement. As Jeremy Brecher has aptly put it: "In fact, revolutionary movements rarely begin with a revolutionary intention; this only develops in the course of the struggle itself."[42] True enough, revolutionary organizations and ideologies have helped to cement the solidarity of radical vanguards before and/or during revolutionary crises. And they have greatly facilitated the con-

—Theda Skocpol. 1979. *States and Social Revolutions*. Cambridge University Press (p.5).

NON-VOLUNTARISM

solidation of new regimes. But in no sense did such vanguards—let alone vanguards with large, mobilized, and ideologically imbued mass followings—ever create the revolutionary crises they exploited. Instead, as we shall see in later chapters, revolutionary situations have developed due to the emergence of politico-military crises of state and class domination. And only because of the possibilities thus created have revolutionary leaderships and rebellious masses contributed to the accomplishment of revolutionary transformations. Besides, the rebellious masses have quite often acted on their own, without being directly organized or ideologically inspired by avowedly revolutionary leaders and goals. As far as the causes of historical social revolutions go, Wendell Phillips was quite correct when he once declared: "Revolutions are not made; they come."[43]

—Theda Skocpol. 1979. *States and Social Revolutions*. Cambridge University Press (p.5).

NON-VOLUNTARISM

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Skocpol identifies conditions said to be both necessary and sufficient for "social revolutions" (def. as a radical realignment in class relations):

* International pressure from more advanced states (esp. intense after defeats in war or threats of invasion);
* Economic/political elites have enough autonomy and power to resist state reforms (launched to appropriate more resources in order to confront the international threat) and precipitate a crisis;
* Organizations are there to mobilize lower classes, exploit elite conflict to radically transform state/society.

Outcomes depend on the presence or absence of these conditions.

CRITIQUES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

- Revolutions can happen for reasons other than a threatening international context, as other factors (e.g., population growth) can destabilize a regime.
- The nature/extent of the change is not determined entirely by structural factors, but also by ideas and choices made by revolutionaries; even in a similar structural context, outcomes of revolutions vary with the kind of movement that topples the regime and what its leaders actually do, or what they fail to do.
- Note that Skocpol has nothing to say about the collective action problem: there's no mechanism for why structural conditions lead to mass mobilization. How international pressures and elite divisions could ever combine to cause someone to wake up one morning suddenly willing to sacrifice his/her life to participate in a protest remains a mystery.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

The dominant approach in social movement theory (by D. McAdam, S. Tarrow, and C. Tilly, or McTT) emphasizes “political opportunity structures” (P.O.S.).

The approach is still largely structuralist (like Skocpol’s), but more “voluntaristic,” integrating insights about culture and rationality.

The approach originates from Tilly’s critique of “relative deprivation,” which argued that protest is not the result of grievances, but of the emergence of organized contenders that mobilize resources and popular support effectively.

The P.O.S. approach was born as a fusion between two of the structural approaches described in one of today’s readings: “resource mobilization" and “political process.”

RESOURCE MOBILIZATION

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

The approach moves away from the emphasis on grievances; more than grievances, it's the mobilization of resources that matters:

> The resource mobilisation approach examines the variety of resources that must be mobilized, the linkages of social movements to other groups, the dependence of movements upon external support for success, and the tactics used by authorities to control or incorporate movements (McCarthy and Zald 1977).

Looks at the process by which a dissatisfied group mobilizes resources ranging from material to intangible. The success of a movement is facilitated by its target group's pre-existing organization, its integration/cohesiveness. From the reading:

> In summary, people protest from a resource mobilization perspective because they are able to mobilize resources and feel politically successful. Prototypical protesters are rational, well-organized, professional, and resourceful people who undertake well-planned collective action with the goal of solving social problems.

POLITICAL PROCESS

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

From the reading:

> While resource mobilization theorists explain the rise and fall of social movements by features internal to the movements themselves, such as the availability of resources and organizational aspects, political process theorists focus on external features, like changes or differences in the political and institutional environment of social movements.
>
> [...]
>
> The paradigm proposes changes in or differences between political structures as the main explanation for the rise and fall of social movements and that differences from one country or era to another stem from the process by which a national political system shapes, checks and absorbs the challenges confronting it.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

McTT's theory consists of three main components:

1. POLITICAL OPPORTUNITIES/CONSTRAINTS

These are structural conditions whose change over time makes dissidents more/less likely to act, or create more or less favorable circumstances for the success of the mobilization process.

Similar to Skocpol's argument about revolutionaries not "making" the revolutionary crises they exploit, but focuses on a broader range of structural factors that might spring a movement into action (e.g.: international pressures, political reforms, elite divisions, socio-economic/demographic/technological change, economic crisis/depression, etc.).

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Also, the P.O.S. approach makes more of an attempt to link structure and individual behaviour, focusing on how (structural) political opportunities may affect the costs of individual participation in social movements.

“Political opportunities” are defined as: Consistent–not necessarily formal or permanent–dimensions of a political environment that provide incentives for collective actions by affecting people’s expectation for success or failure.

“Political constraints” do the opposite: Some authors have emphasised the opportunities/constraints generated by different aspects of the institutional structure or political context to explain how protest varies across countries.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

2. MOBILIZATION STRUCTURES

The capacity to put together hierarchical organizations that link leaders/followers, center/periphery, and different wings of the movement together is key in order to establish trust, mobilize resources, coordinate action.

Availability of resources (financial/organizational, leadership, symbolic/cultural/intellectual, etc.) makes the movement more likely to mobilize people effectively and to succeed.

Often crucial is the movement's reliance on resources mobilized through pre-existing social relations, institutions, organizations.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Organizational resources: May include money, training, weapons, safe houses, bases, etc. (such resources may come from contributors or "patrons," whether domestic or foreign, or profits from illicit activities such as kidnapping, bank robbery, drug trafficking).

If they become involved, pre-existing organizations can provide key support for the movement (e.g., black churches in the U.S. civil rights movement; mosques in the 1979 Iranian revolution; labor unions in struggles by socialist movements; professional associations in struggles by middle classes).

Leadership resources: Presence of experienced leaders with vision and know-how, strategic acumen, oratory or organizational skills.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Cultural/symbolic/intellectual resources: Movements can benefit from endorsement of "communal" elites (religious/ethnic leaders), intellectuals, or widely respected celebrities and organizations, who can give the movement greater visibility and credibility.

Also potentially important is the appropriation and use of established and meaningful symbols in an effort to boost the movement's image (at least with certain groups), to make the movement appear worth joining, and to increase the sense of cultural or historical legitimacy of the struggle waged by the movement.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

3. COGNITIVE FRAMES

Refers to capacity of leaders to provide a cognitive framework that convinces supporters of the need to protest and of the likely effectiveness of doing so.

Here, the recourse to ideology and/or the ability to construct a narrative for a movement's sense of historical purpose or mission is key, as are the words chosen to inspire people to participate.

The emphasis the approach places on frames makes the success of a movement and the outcomes of mobilization more open to the effects of choice and more dependent on the capacity of leaders to shape their followers' cognitive and decision-making processes.

CRITIQUES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

While the approach is more sophisticated, focusing on political opportunities presents similar problems as relative deprivation.

[i] In retrospect, proponents can always begin with a social movement and look back at the opportunity that caused it to succeed. This is a bit like assuming the answer: the analytical strategy makes sense only if one is already convinced that political opportunities are the cause.

The approach has yet to specify precise features that make it possible to identify political opportunities independently of the outcome (i.e., “to know one when one sees one”); the tendency is to classify developments as opportunities only in retrospect.

CRITIQUES

[ii] This poses another problem. If political opportunities are defined by objective criteria, it is likely that in most instances one sees no exact correspondence with action (e.g., elite divisions don't always cause mobilization).

In this case, P.O.S. theorists might explain negative cases (no mobilization) by finding a reason why the group's resources/framing was not effective. Again, this tends to assume the answer.

Again, the problem is that the approach does not provide a mechanism for the mobilization of individuals; the argument that opportunities decrease the costs of participation is not much of a solution for the collective action problem.

CRITIQUES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

A fix might be to say that political opportunities only matter when they are perceived as such (just like deprivation matters only when felt as such). In fact, this is what P.O.S. scholars say.

But, this also raises the question of whether it is even useful to think in terms of structurally created opportunities, as followers can be made to feel that opportunities (just like grievances) exist regardless of objective conditions.

Then, the question becomes not which opportunities/grievances lead to action, but how participants come to perceive them, as a result of mobilization, and how they are motivated to take action on that basis, perhaps at times against self-interest.

CRITIQUES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

This reasoning calls into question the importance of structure. This is not to say that class relations, international context, elite divisions, and macro-historical processes like state formation or nation building don't matter.

In fact, they do matter because they set obstacles that the leaders of social movements face and the options available to them (e.g., there will be no peasant revolution in advanced industrial societies), making different outcomes more or less *likely* at the outset.

But, structure does not *wholly* determine outcomes, which are sensitive to both choice and chance, rendering specific outbreaks of protest unpredictable.

CRITIQUES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

In each specific instance, what determines the outcome is how leaders respond to the challenges/incentives/constraints provided by structure, their success in motivating followers, and the results of their strategic interactions with the state and other non-state actors.

That means that tactical/strategic aspects are key (Week 4).

Moreover, it brings us back to the question: how is the collective action problem, which works against individual participation, solved? (Week 3)

CRITIQUES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

As a preview, the key is to return to the individual, but supplement the emphasis on self-interest with a focus on the instinctive, emotional, and moral bases of action, paying attention to how the mobilization of resources as well as the movement's framing activities activate certain psychological mechanisms/processes.

Another key is to consider individuals not in isolation, but as embedded in a web of social relations (family, friends, school, work, political/social/communal organizations, class, ethnicity, region, etc.) through which one acquires certain preferences, values, worldviews, and identities. These communities also shape individual action by administering social and psychological rewards or costs for different behaviours.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORIES

Saying that self-interest does not explain all behavior amounts to saying that behavior can be motivated by other factors. What else motivates behavior?

[i] Human beings are animated by passions or emotions (anger, resentment, fear, desire to seek reassurance by adopting behaviour that "fits in," or impulse to differentiate themselves from others by not "fitting in"); perhaps above all, people care about their self-image and their public image, something that often leads them to think not very rationally and act in ways that contradict self-interest.

[ii] Human beings have a natural impulse to engage in "self-categorization" (i.e., define their identity in terms of group membership) and practice "parochial altruism" (i.e., favor people, even unknown people, seen as members of the same group, while discriminating against others).

[iii] Human beings are, in Jeremy Beetham's words, "moral agents" who have "some notion of the common interest, and acknowledge the binding force of promises they have made"—i.e., they tend to do what they think it's right even if it doesn't maximize self-interest. Note: Not always a good thing.